



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 36

OHIO

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Ohio's family courts and child-welfare system.

111

OHIO FAMILIES ON RECORD · 140
CHILDREN IMPACTED · 18 MONTHS
MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF PARENTING
TIME

REPORT GENERATED
APRIL 29, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED
40 OF 88

COMPILED BY
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

OHIO AT A GLANCE.

Across 111 Ohio families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 140 108 of 111 families reported child counts	MEDIAN ATTORNEY FEES \$15,000 per reporting family	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 18 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 48.6% 32.4% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 111	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.3	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN 108 of 111	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 40

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Ohio families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02 THE COST OF OHIO FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	62	\$15,000	\$70,917	\$4,396,830
Lost Wages	55	\$5,300	\$118,149	\$6,498,190
Other Court Fees	42	\$532	\$3,855	\$161,915
Therapy / Evaluations	46	\$1,000	\$7,121	\$327,560
Reunification Services	48	\$150	\$2,764	\$132,680
GAL Fees	55	\$1,600	\$5,766	\$317,150
Asset Loss ¹	49	\$10,000	—	—
Estimated Median Family Impact	—	\$33,582	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers.

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$10,000) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Median months lost		18	1.5 yrs
Mean months lost		30	2.5 yrs
Total across all families		1,742	145.2 yrs

03 WHO IS REPORTING · OHIO

Most families documenting in Ohio are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Active case: stuck or delayed		48	43%
Not provided		33	30%
Case closed: within last 2 years		15	14%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago		11	10%
I am currently in an active case (progress is being made)		1	1%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and CPS		50	45%
Family Court Only		33	30%
Unknown		22	20%
CPS (Child Protective Services) Only		3	3%
Foster Care / Termination of Parental Rights (TPR)		1	1%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		26	23%
3 – 5 years		20	18%
Over 10 years		11	10%
6 months – 1 year		9	8%
5 – 10 years		9	8%

CUSTODY STATUS

Visitation Only		36	32%
No Contact / Total Loss of Access		32	29%
50/50 Joint		15	14%
Full Custody		11	10%
Adopted Out (Rights Terminated)		7	6%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Montgomery		5	5%
Hancock		5	5%
Butler		4	4%
Hamilton		4	4%
Stark		3	3%
Clark		3	3%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)		28	25%
Other: (Short answer)		14	13%
False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)		12	11%
Family Court		12	11%
High Conflict Divorce		8	7%

05 PARENT VOICES — OHIO

Selected voice excerpts appear here for readability. Every approved, shareable Ohio comment is printed in full in the appendix that follows.



Terminated my Parental Rights in Fraud and destroyed my children.

— PATSY

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

Kids taken without hearing. Zero evidence of abuse or neglect. When I responded and called them all out on Facebook I was punished with jail time and more lost time with my children. My ex and my ex boss got together and turned my posts into my coal mining job for 12 years I was [...]

— OHIO PARENT · NICK

MORE VOICES FROM OHIO

False claims to CPS by my boyfriend's ex girlfriend. Kids were on a safety plan for 2 weeks while I got drug tested and came back negative

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Took my grandson away and gave him to the abusers who then kept him and his siblings from coming home to me

— ROBIN

Because I'm deaf - system use my abuser and his mother as their primary and believe them because they have voice and I don't. They lie a lot about me. Judge refused to see my proof motion. They never on my side. I even show them my proof of abuser hit me and raped me. The judge [...]

— AVRIL

They took away my rights as a mother to raise my children as I see fit. I was always either a stay at home mom or I worked as needed and was forced to work full-time. They took my kids away during the school time, but not during the summer, because I didn't believe in the very [...]

— KAYLEIGH

The depression and hurt of not being able to a mother to your children is devastating. My children suffered abuse and mental health abuse.

— BELINDA

This system has ripped my kids from wverything they knew. They have caused hurt anger and my kids are suffering and lashing out.

— MERSADEES

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED


Falsely accused us of abuse and tore our family apart

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

My daughter wants to move back with me no abuse or anything judge just sides with his attorney and can't even tell me what I've done wrong I swore at her in a text

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Shattered the relationship with son, destroyed my son's image of me, his self esteem, his identity, placed him in the home with the abuser.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Illegal alien with a conviction of sexual abuse of a child was given full custody of a minor child. Parental (entire maternal family) alienation has been endorsed by family court.

— ROBYN

This system stole all 5 of my son's children from our ENTIRE family. Even though I had 2 of these kids as an emergency placement, and kinship placement of my nephew, these children have been kept from the entire paternal side.

— ROBYN

I have been grieving my kids that are STILL ALIVE because of the Clark county ohio family court!! LOST MEMORIES, LOST TIMES, AND A BONDS STOLEN . just like that....gone I LOVE YOU JULIUS AND BRYLON

— BRIANNA

An assistant prosecuting attorney acting as a civil custody lawyer al fight and suppressed a 25 year violent criminal history for his private client. Attorneys judges, GALCPS and even neighboring counties are working together, not in the best interest of the child, but in the [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I cry every day, it was always me and my son, every day since he was born, I look at the pictures of me and him together my son clinging onto me when he was little and I break down and cry, we used to order pizza and have pizza and movie night once a month, I taught my son how [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Turned me into a civil rights activist.

— CAREY ANN

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Removed my kids to ex parte without letting my attorney know.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Took away our entire lives. Completely destroyed our mental health. Made my children believe I'm the bad guy and don't love them or care about them. Told them I wasn't their mother and their father wasn't their father.

— ALEXANDREA

Allowed this person to commit criminal crimes against me by not allowing me to see my children and has gotten away with every single one.

— SARA

This system has caused a ginormous splinter in the bond I hold with my children. Refused and erased my ancestral traditions and our way of life.

— RAVEN

took my daughter who was sexually abused, and put her back with her abuser in the same home the abuse occurred. she then got molested again in under a month of contact

— HEIDI

It has caused severe trauma for both of us. My daughter is not getting the medical care she needs, and I worry about her safety everyday. My daughter already had anxiety prior to separation. they destroyed our bond and all the good things ive done her whole life.

— HEATHER

The system has single-handedly divided and destroyed my sense of security, my sense of peace, my children from my life and allowed the abuser to publicly look like a hero, forcing the mother to pay a child support for two kids while residing in Ohio and kids being in California [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I'm not in the good ole boys and girls club. Ex wife, her husband, lawyer, judge and child support are.

— CHRISTOPHER

Created litigation abuse, DARVO, violates the constitution land of law, me allowing to speak, violation of due process.

— JESSICA

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



The system falsely accused my fiancé, and then even after her charge have been dismissed. I am now still being punished years later.

— RACHEL

They destroyed our confidence and consistency. They destroyed my child's mental health and mine. They did nothing but lie to help make that happen.

— ANNA

Butler and warren county ohio destroyed my family and took time I will never get back

— JESSICA

It has caused further trauma, cause children to cry out for help and be denied so they turn to committing crimes as thats what they are being taught instead of protected. It tears apart siblings and grandparents and great grandparents.

— CATHERINE

Despite having a protection order and evidence of abuse and coercive control and opposing party not following any court orders (psych evaluation and hair strand test) and having multiple contempts of court, the GAL is suggesting joint custody.

— EMILY

Complete and total destruction of our happy, loving family with use of psychological warfare to all 3 of my children and myself!

— RENE

The courts didn't just take my rights — they took my child, my time, my voice, my safety, and the chance to protect the one person who depended on me to survive.

— TACI

Took my entire life, my motherhood, my job, my car, my home, my safety and security, my trust in the system, my wellbeing. Most importantly my three daughters childhoods, innocence, and child parent relationship.

— MARISSA

They do not do anything for interference of custody. No consequences so far this will be his second

— EMILY

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



I moved to a different state after my kids were taken. I went from a successful career driven single mother to an unemployed, homeless woman in full blown active addiction where I am currently.

— AMBER

Has taken everything i had purpose to live for

— AMANDA

Destoryed everthing i built and handed it to the person who abandon us for years.

— MEGAN

My child was taken at birth without any allegations of abuse or neglect, based solely on a past case, and I have been left without clear reunification steps while being limited to minimal visitation.”

— JUSTIN

“Truth doesn’t panic when it’s questioned. Stay patient—what’s real has a way of rising to the surface.”

— MOLLY

Cps has done so much pain for my family that I cant get back 2 years

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Took my kids out of a loving home to place them where ever they could following all the recommendations they set to have unsupervised visits so we can move on to overnight and then home but I never one time got more parenting time or any of the unsupervised visits or overnight. [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has completely broke us and failed us. Out of all the people that I know in our county it has lost their children to the system. I am the only one that was able to get mine back..

— MATTALYNN

“This system drained our family emotionally and financially, forcing us to spend everything we had just to be heard, while separating us from our children without timely answers or accountability. It turned protection into punishment and survival into a constant fight.”

— BRITNEY

65 Ohio parents submitted approved, shareable comments. 44 selected excerpts appear here; the full comments begin on the next page.

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS — OHIO

The comments below are the full approved, publicly shareable survey comments from Ohio families. Data-only and do-not-share submissions are excluded from this public appendix.

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Because I'm deaf - system use my abuser and his mother as their primary and believe them because they have voice and I don't. They lie a lot about me. Judge refused to see my proof motion. They never on my side. I even show them my proof of abuser hit me and raped me. The judge said I'm a bad mother because of interpreter - like serious? I need correct interpreter for my language rights. They put my abuser as 100 kid custody and gave me a hard time! I didn't see my kids for two years!

— AVRIL

They took away my rights as a mother to raise my children as I see fit. I was always either a stay at home mom or I worked as needed and was forced to work full-time. They took my kids away during the school time, but not during the summer, because I didn't believe in the very young children being in sports on Sunday as it is our only day together as a family. My ex-husband believed not vaccinating our children when they were young and used it against me to gain full custody and full medical over me. I was forced to pay child support to him even though he makes \$80,000 a year I make 20,000 and has taken away from the kids when they are here.

— KAYLEIGH

The depression and hurt of not being able to a mother to your children is devastating. My children suffered abuse and mental health abuse.

— BELINDA

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

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— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I cry every day, it was always me and my son, every day since he was born, I look at the pictures of me and him together my son clinging onto me when he was little and I break down and cry, we used to order pizza and have pizza and movie night once a month, I taught my son how to cook and we would make dinner together and have dinner and movie night and sit and talk about anything and everything, my son is my whole world, my everything, the family court system and CPS gave my son to the father who was never around and thousands of dollars behind in back child support, I did everything on my own (with help of my grandparent's, aunt and uncle who raised me) but mostly it was always me as the full time parent 24/7 every day for 13 close to 14 years, my son was always in perfect health, had everything he ever wanted and needed, I provided everything, I made sure he always had an education and went to the doctor, when we both got COVID I still took care of my son even though I myself was sick, because mom's don't get sick days, I even offered to give up child support since that was the reason my ex wanted custody, I only want my son, he's my baby, he will always be my baby, now all I have left is pictures and memories and so much hurt and pain, all because of pictures of MY private bedroom being messy taken without my knowledge or consent and sent to CPS, and because CPS and a police officer entered my home without a court order by means of a threat and CPS took my son away on a cold December night, CPS even made my son stand outside in the freezing temperatures for close to an hour they wouldn't even allow my son to go inside where it was warm, and while he was at the "group

— ANONYMOUS PARENT (1/4)

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

home” CASA and CPS told my son inappropriate things regarding my friends private medical, my ex (his father) told my son “I’m a wh*re” when I’m a strict Christian with strong Christian beliefs, I remember a time my longtime best friend from school gave me a ride to pick up my son for the weekend while he was in state/county care and the caseworker called and demanded that I return my son because my friend and her husband needed to be “CPS approved” (fingerprint and BCI background and drug tested” in order to drive me to pick up my son, and my friend and her husband don’t even smoke cigarettes !! This has not only affected me but it also affected my son, the group home made my son push mow a field all summer in the hot sun even on heat advisory days with an infected ingrown toenail while my son was limping in pain, and one foster home was ate up with bed bugs and my son had bug bites all over him, my son said they made him sleep on a bed bugs infested bed with only one sheet and one pillow, now my son is living in a one room apartment shared with 3 other people, no bedroom, a messy apartment, and with his father who never was around or had a part in raising him, my son is angry and hurt, and so am I, laws need to change, unless a house is a hoarding situation they should leave a simple messy house alone, because now both me and my child was extremely hurt, a one happy home completely ripped apart, a child being ripped away from the only parent he ever had, so much hurt was caused by CPS, CASA, Family Court, and the so called public pretender, the more people speak up, the more attention gets drawn, and hopefully lawmakers will change the laws, but that requires the states

— ANONYMOUS PARENT (2/4)

governor (in my case Ohio) to actually care, I’ve called the governor, state representatives, ombudsman, and nothing happened, nobody cared, and if the caseworker knew I spoke up who knows what retaliation would happen, since the court put a “gag-order” on me !! They don’t want parents to speak up, because how dare the parents fight back !! Every CPS case NEEDS to be reopened and investigated by the higher courts because there are so many innocent and good parents who have had their child/children taken for the most ridiculous reasons, Clermont County Ohio is always in the spotlight for bad things, they take children from good home and place them in horrible situations, one caseworker told me he was due to remove 10 different children from different homes all in one day, and that speaks volumes, the caseworker (at the time) told me “there are so many kid’s in the system in this county they don’t have enough homes to place them” and that’s why my son was sent three or four counties away !! It’s time that every parent speak up and tell their stories, because if not this will keep happening !! We all need to get up and take a stand, I have not been the same emotionally since my son was taken, my heart is so broken, I just want my son back in my arms, Supreme Court NEEDS to do something to fix what COS and family court is doing, they cause more harm than good, and it will keep happening if laws are not changed, look up Clermont County Ohio CPS, they are known for shady stuff and targeting innocent parents more so single mom’s, if I could afford a paid lawyer my case would have been won easily, but due to disability and disability income I couldn’t afford one, and they sure

— ANONYMOUS PARENT (3/4)

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

had no problem holding disability against me, I might be disabled but I'm not incompetent to where I can't be a mom, after all I was a mom for 13 years, and I have the documents to show it, I save everything, I have a treasure trove of documents I'm willing to share !!

— ANONYMOUS PARENT (4/4)

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— CAREY ANN

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— ANONYMOUS PARENT

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— MATTALYNN

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

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— BRITNEY

Took phone calls away my visits ect please call I have so much to say

— TRISHA

The court process has turned what should have been a child-focused custody matter into years of instability, forced separation, and emotional strain on my children and me. The lack of accountability has caused lasting harm to our family relationships

— ANNA

My family has turned their back on each other has broken sibling bonds and made some of my kids rebel against the system and caused trust issues against the system

— ANDREA

Violated my rights kidnapped my child and used her estate as leverage of extortion in commerce against me using a fictitious scarecrow and tricking me into their jurisdiction to be used in commerce as a current day slave.

— HARLEY

Has made my life harder financially, mentally and it's made me lose hope that the system is good and fair and needed

— ROBERT

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Caused so much trauma and left us in a hole almost impossible to get out of and with destruction waiting at the top when we do. And my babies will be permanently and for a lifetime affected by decisions and not investigations. For money and not protection. They made it impossible for Me to ever be the mom I dreamed of being and broke the mom I was-I live in fear of needing to ever protect my children-all because I told it was safe to ask them for help and they would help me and my babies.

— TALISHA

Completely ruined my life and changed the outcome of my daughters life.

— JENNIFER

My son wasn't abused — he was acting out at his dad's house because he was desperate for his father's attention. Instead of listening to the truth, the system blamed me, twisted his pain into something it wasn't, and handed my child to the very parent who was barely there for him

— ALYSSA

Despite absolutely stealing my children, the system has worked feverishly to ruin my career, evict me from my home, turn friends against me, ruin my reputation, put me in prison, and bankrupt me all to get me to give up, take a plea and walk away. Acting in the best interest of the kids is a fallacy —because the goal was never “justice for the kids,” it was to weaponize compliance.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I spent 25 plus years living in an abusive, unsupportive and neglectful marriage. The family court system is equally abusive, unsupportive and neglectful. There is no “justice” in our justice system. The priorities of the court is for profit - not “for the people”.. (I wish I could speak to someone directly as my case has been very unique since the opposition was a former sheriff. I was told at one point I could not even file for a protection order because it was a conflict of interest and I wouldn't have a judge to sign it). Criminal investigations were pushed off to the state and severely delayed or ignored) my children are no longer minors. It was not safe for me to leave while he was sheriff as he threatened to use the system against me the entire time. I had no where to turn.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Failed to protect a 3 yr old and openly fed her to a monster pedophile and created lifelong trauma and forced us to live in the hood I was a stay at home mom for over 2 yrs cut off funds, removed me. From home

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system is an absolute disgrace, it's ruined my children's lives and my life. The system is a child trafficking ring - children go to the highest bidder.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They took everything from us, they literally tried to murder us, but we're still standing. Anyone that obsessed with controlling another person needs to be institutionalized.

— NICOLE

I lost all respect for the justice system. I am afraid to speak up because its so clear how deeply this evil goes.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Financial devastation. Emotionally crippled

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This county had 2 cases found nothing went for gaurdianship over our daughter because jfs would not leave her alone. The Magistrate from that hearing ordered our grandson removed immediately because she didn't want our grandson growing up like our daughter

— GEORGE

There are no words or way to describe the mix of grief, pain, shame, confusion, anger and fear I face from the second I wake up until the moment I close my eyes.

— STEVIE

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Total alienation from my daughter, assaulted physically, sheriff good ol boys refused reports every time I wanted one, denied access to my daughter was not allowed to file contempt, denied medical attention by sheriff when assaulted causing bodily harm, physically and mentally exhausted, broke, alination from my daughter., ptsd

— RHIANNA

The overt actions and inaction of bad actors within the family court system have forced my child to endure ongoing emotional and physical harm while I have been drained emotionally, financially, professionally and psychologically trying to protect her. Instead of intervening to stop the suffering, the family court system has partnered with the juvenile court system to intentionally keep both of us trapped in prolonged trauma.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Magistrate X, you moved my son 1,000 miles away and while not even spending the paltry 75 days with me, G somehow blames me for everything wrong in his life and has cut me out of his life. If that's not parental alienation, I don't know what is. Your choice to have G live with that man was wrong and will sadly affect him, his mental health, as well as all of his Ohio family for the rest of our lives.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I believe that it boils down to which parent has the most money and can pay for representation. My daughter is 21 years old now and has an emotional issues because of what her father has done. Parent alienation is real and I submitted evidence that he was doing this to my daughter and it was looked over. The last time we went to court, I was told if he continued to act in the same manner that we could go to court once again.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

65 full approved Ohio comments are included in this appendix.

07 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Ohio report comes from Ohio respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Ohio — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 111 Ohio families reporting here are not the universe of Ohio families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – April 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 5 independent families name the same actor.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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